RAJWANT RAWAT



YASH SAMPAT, 33

Advocate, New Delhi

‘Spiritual grounding brings me clarity’

Yash is a regular at Swaminarayan temples—Akshardham in Delhi when home (*in pic*), in other cities when work takes him there. Since 2006, he has attended weekly Bal Sabhas, marked by satsang, seva and a quiet walk past carved pillars. For this young advocate, court diaries can be chaotic, briefs multiplying hourly. The temple, he says, gives him clarity. “My spiritual grounding helps me see issues more broadly and respond with balance.” He values how sabhas weave peers and mentors together through shared service and bonhomie after aarti. The result: sharper focus and a habit of giving back. ■

A steep, breathless ascent where the air thinned and conversations shrank to a bare minimum. Heels gave way to hiking boots. Buffets became whatever fit in their backpacks. They started before sunrise, ponchos rustling, phones on airplane mode, minds oddly alert. The last zigzags hurt. The bells grew louder. At the shrine, they stood still, eyes wet, palms warm. “We went out of curiosity,” says Ira, “but found a kind of peace we didn’t know we were missing.” Now, they go yearly.

That impulse is spreading. Temples are drawing a surge of Gen Z seekers—driven by belonging, spiritual curiosity and the quiet pull of social currency. This movement is bolstered by tech: Char Dham registration sits on Uttarakhand’s ‘Tourist Care’ app; Tirupati’s ‘TTD’ app manages slot-booked darshan, rooms, sevas and donations; Kashi Vishwanath offers live aarti and e-bookings—replacing middlemen with digital gateways.

Operators feel the shift. Divine Trails, an adventure-led pilgrimage outfit that arranges Himalayan yatras and handles permits, porters and homestays, reports a steady rise in enquiries from younger travellers. Founder Dinesh Rathod says renovated corridors, faster roads and social media are pulling under-35s to popular circuits such as Kedarnath, Hemkund with the Valley of Flowers, the Char Dham and Adi Kailash in Uttarakhand. “At least a quarter to a third of new queries are from them,” he says. Divine India Holidays, a temple-and-heritage tour company, sees the same tilt towards compact trips blending trekking, heritage and food. Founder Vineet Chaubey says, “Char Dham and Do Dham with nature add-ons are hot, as are Ramayana circuits and south India temple trails—people want culture, photos and a good thali in the same weekend.”

The numbers back it. IXIGO, an online travel company, says half of Mahakumbh Mela attendees in 2025 were under 30, with 26 per cent aged 20–25. Kantar TGI, a comprehensive consumer insights tool that surveyed 63,622 urban and rural Indians, shows that in 2024, one in four Indians travelled to a religious destination, with most travellers aged 25–44. Those aged 25–34 led the count in Haridwar, while the 35–44s predominated in Ayodhya.

Beyond visits, participation is deepening. Bochasanwasi Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha (BAPS), which runs Akshardham temples worldwide, notes teenagers and young adults in weekly satsang sabhas across its network. Yash Sampat, a 33-year-old advocate from New Delhi, is among them (see case study *‘Spiritual ground-*

THEY ARE THE KIND OF COUPLE WHO BRUNCH AT KHAN MARKET AND SKI IN GULMARG. Ira Kapoor, 26, is a brand manager in Gurugram, while her partner, 27-year-old Karan Malhotra, is an investment analyst. For the first anniversary of their relationship, they chose Kedarnath. Not a hotel. Not a tasting menu.